

In the story of the coat of many colors, for example, Joseph's brothers were so jealous they tried to kill him. So did emperors and kings throughout history murder their rivals with tedious frequency. Being the younger brother of a successful general or a king was often dangerous.

Gradually, more peaceful methods of dividing and managing wealth were developed. Younger brothers were given dukedoms or kingdoms of their own. Successful generals were kept away from the centers of power.

Generals often captured the loyalty of their men. In the Roman Republic, for example, generals were not allowed to return to Rome with their troops.

That is, of course, why "crossing the Rubicon" was such a big deal. Caesar broke the law of the republic and turned Rome into an empire. This opened the door to another go-round of succession battles. By (now) long tradition, in modern countries military authorities are subordinate to civilian authorities.

Intrafamily institutions for managing wealth appeared at least as early as the Roman era. A family would hire an administrator, a *major domus*, who became a *major domo* in the Middle Ages, to run its financial and business affairs. While family members proliferated, heads of families and administrators realized that there was a benefit to keeping wealth intact and centrally managed.

Europe developed the *fideicomiso*, which held wealth together, even as the family expanded and dispersed. Then private bankers took on the task of looking out for a family's wealth—for a fee, of course. Trusts were developed to hold wealth, and then became an industry as well as a financial instrument.

The Industrial Revolution was a period of rapid capital accumulation. It brought a new kind of wealth that was neither directly connected to dirt nor the residue of ancient plunder.

Until the nineteenth century, most wealth was in the form of land. Most people were farmers. And most of the wealth they had was in acreage and what it would produce. This made succession an easier matter than it is today. A young man had few options. And he had a keen interest in protecting what was then the family patrimony: the land. He naturally stepped into the shoes of his father, if he could, and then left them for his own son.